

PART 1 • THE FORWARD DEPLOYED
STRATEGIST

Forward deployment always sent two.

The fastest-growing role in AI

The Forward Deployed Engineer is the fastest-growing role in AI. Postings are up roughly 10x in 18 months, and total comp runs \$300K–\$600K+.

New York overtook San Francisco

New York now holds about 35% of U.S. forward-deployed postings versus SF's 11% — concentrated in fintech and other regulated industries.

Palantir never sent one person

It sent two: the Forward Deployed Engineer who writes the code, and the Deployment Strategist who defines the outcome.

The hiring frenzy stuffs one seat

Almost every posting is written as an engineering role. The scarce half of the job isn't the engineering — it's the forward.

Both strategist industries are contracting

McKinsey's growth slowed to roughly 2% while headcount fell about 10%. WPP's revenue fell 6.6% in Q1 2026 even as worldwide ad spend grew 8.6%.

The method never changed

Only the medium did. The creative brief becomes the system prompt. The campaign rollout becomes the agent in production. The measurement plan becomes the eval harness.

A demand-side failure, not a modeling one

Gartner expects more than 40% of agentic AI projects to be cancelled by 2027 — on unclear business value and inadequate controls.

What actually changed

With Claude, MCP, and modern agent frameworks, the person who understands the business problem can now build and operate the solution.

Receipts.

BLOOMBERRY / PARAFORM, 2026

10x growth in forward-deployed postings over 18 months; New York ~35% of U.S. postings vs San Francisco's 11%

GARTNER

More than 40% of agentic AI projects expected to be cancelled by 2027

MCKINSEY, PUBLIC REPORTING

Revenue growth ~2%, headcount down ~10%

WPP, PUBLIC REPORTING

Revenue -6.6% in Q1 2026 while worldwide ad spend grew 8.6%

Agents live, results flat?

We run production-gap reviews.
ensolabs.ai/contact
